

MICA Arm 3 — the weekly text messages

What we can check today, and two decisions we need from you · 15 September 2026

The short version. The weekly texts are not yet switched on — nothing in the study schedules them, so there is no “wait for the text to arrive” check we can run for you today.

When we opened the weekly message survey as a participant would see it, REDCap stopped it with an error and refused to let the page continue. The survey is still carrying settings from the earlier ASPIRE/TRAM study it was copied from.

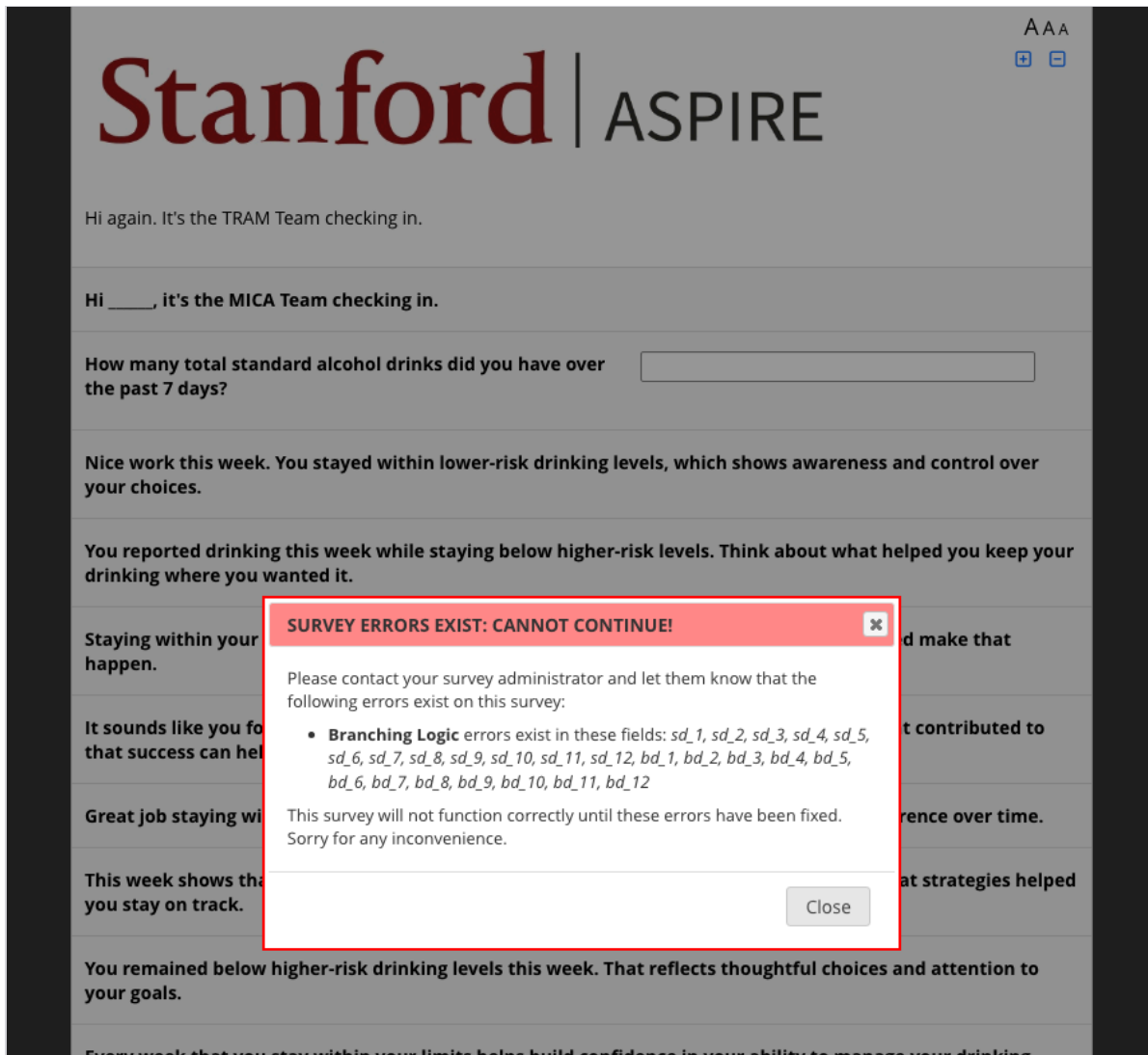
The good news: texting itself works. This project already sends real SMS to real phones, and we have confirmed Arm 3 keeps to its own schedule. What is missing is the weekly *cadence* — and that needs two decisions from you before we can build it.

What we would like from you: the two answers in section 3, and — whenever suits — a read of the 63 messages in the appendix. That review is genuinely on the critical path and does not depend on any of the technical work.

Which copy of the study this describes. Everything below was checked on the development copy of MICA that we build and test against. The copy on the Stanford server is set up separately — some changes have to be re-applied there by hand — so we are re-running these same checks there and will confirm or correct this document. We do not expect a different answer, but we would rather tell you that up front than have you read this as a report on the server copy.

1 What the weekly survey looks like right now

This is the real participant link for a test Arm 3 participant, opened in a browser. Nothing is staged or simulated:



Top of the weekly survey, as a participant would see it today. Four things to notice: the red box is REDCap refusing to run the survey; the greeting reads “Hi _____” because the name is being looked up in a study event that no longer exists; the page opens with “It’s the **TRAM** Team checking in”; and the encouraging message (“You stayed within lower-risk drinking levels”) is stacked directly on top of the concerned one (“This week’s drinking was in the range considered unhealthy”).

All 24 feedback messages display at the same time — both the “you stayed within your limits” set and the “this week was above healthy limits” set. We tried entering 10 drinks to see whether the right set would be picked; nothing changed. The comparison the survey uses is looking for a number that is no longer where it expects it, so it cannot tell the two situations apart.

Separately, 37 of the messages — the whole “drank nothing this week” set and both goal-setting sets — never appear at all. They are set to show in “week 1” through “week 12”, and Arm 3 currently has a single combined “Weeks 1–12” period rather than twelve separate weeks. That is the heart of decision A below.

2 What already works, so you know where the gap is

CAPABILITY	STATUS
A text message leaves the study and arrives on a real phone	Confirmed
Participant phone numbers are accepted as text recipients	Confirmed
Arm 3 keeps to its own schedule — no messages leak to other arms	Confirmed
The passcode text and the opt-out confirmation (both Arm 3)	Clean and MICA-branded
Weekly message content	Written — needs your review
Something that sends the weekly message	Not built — needs decisions A & B
The weekly survey itself	Needs rewiring after A is answered

In other words: the pipes are in and tested. What is missing is the timetable, and the timetable is a study-design question rather than a technical one — which is why we are asking you rather than guessing.

3 The two decisions we need

Decision A — How should the 12 weekly messages sit in the study calendar?

Arm 3 currently has one combined “Weeks 1–12” period, so there is exactly one slot for twelve messages. The earlier ASPIRE study used twelve separate weekly slots instead.

This matters because the messages you will read in the appendix are written as *twelve different messages* — a distinct note for week 1, week 2, and so on. That design only works if there are twelve slots to put them in.

What we need: confirm that each of the 12 weeks should carry its own distinct message (our reading of how the content is written), or tell us the same message may repeat. Your answer determines how we rebuild the survey, so we would rather not assume.

Decision B — Once a week, or twice a week?

ASPIRE texted participants twice weekly — a Sunday check-in and a Thursday message, 24 sends over 12 weeks. MICA has only the Sunday form built.

What we need: Sunday only (12 sends), or Sunday plus a midweek message (24 sends)? If it is the latter, we will also need the midweek message content.

One thing to be aware of — opting out of texts

If a participant replies STOP, the phone carrier blocks further texts immediately, so the participant is protected. But REDCap is never told, so the study record still shows them as receiving texts. Today, someone on the study team has to tick the opt-out box by hand.

No decision needed now — but it is worth adding to the coordinator's routine: on any STOP report, tick the opt-out box on the participant's admin form.

4 What happens after you answer

1. We set up the weekly slots in Arm 3 to match your answer to A.
2. We rewire the weekly survey onto those slots, fix the greeting so it uses the participant's real first name, and make the feedback pick the correct message instead of showing all of them.
3. We change "TRAM Team" to "MICA Team" and give the survey a proper title.
4. We add the scheduler that actually sends the weekly message, with the same protections the other MICA messages already use — nothing goes out to a participant who has withdrawn or opted out.
5. **Then** we run the delivery test you originally asked for, on a real handset, and send you the result.

Steps 1–4 are ours. Only step 1 waits on you.

5 If you would like to see it live

We would normally give you a link to click, but the survey in section 1 lives on a development server that is only reachable from inside our setup — a link would simply fail to open on your machine, which would tell you nothing useful.

So instead: **say the word and we will screen-share it with you**, in about ten minutes. We can scroll through the live survey, show the stacked messages and the blank greeting, and try any "what if we answer it this way" you would like to see. That is also a good moment to walk through the two decisions in section 3 if you would rather talk them through than write them down.

Appendix The weekly message library — 63 messages for your review

This is the exact wording currently stored in the study, grouped by the situation that triggers each message. The “Week” column is the week the message is written for. Reviewing this does not depend on any of the technical work above, so it can happen in parallel — and it is the piece only you can sign off.

Opening line every week

Currently renders as “Hi _____” — the first name is not being found.

— Hi [baseline_arm_1][first_name], it's the MICA Team checking in.

The two questions asked each week

- 1 How many total standard alcohol drinks did you have over the past 7 days?
 - 2 Are you planning on drinking alcohol this week? → if yes: Would you be willing to commit to a goal to drink less than [your threshold]?
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A — Drank nothing this week 12 messages

Shown when the participant reports 0 drinks. *Currently: never displays today*

WEEK	MESSAGE
1	Amazing job staying alcohol-free this week! Your body and mind will thank you for it
2	Staying alcohol-free this week took effort and intention. Give yourself credit for the choices you made along the way.
3	Incredible! You made a smart choice this week, and it's a big step toward your goals.
4	Awesome work! Staying alcohol-free shows your strength and commitment-keep it up!
5	Well done! Skipping alcohol this week is a great way to prioritize your well-being.
6	That's fantastic! You're proving to yourself that you can make choices that align with your goals.
7	Congrats on sticking to your plan this week! Your body and mind will feel the benefits!
8	You crushed it! Another alcohol-free week is another step toward feeling your best.
9	Well done on not drinking this week! It's a big accomplishment-celebrate that!
10	Awesome decision! You're showing how much control and strength you have-keep up the good work!
11	Fantastic! By choosing not to drink, you're setting yourself up for long-term health and success.
12	Great job! You made a choice that supports your goals and shows your dedication to change

B — Drank, but below the risk threshold 12 messages

Shown when drinks are below the participant's threshold (4 or 5, by birth sex). *Currently: all 12 display at once today*

WEEK	MESSAGE
1	Nice work this week. You stayed within lower-risk drinking levels, which shows awareness and control over your choices.
2	You reported drinking this week while staying below higher-risk levels. Think about what helped you keep your drinking where you wanted it.
3	Staying within your limits is an accomplishment. The choices you made along the way helped make that happen.
4	It sounds like you found a balance that worked for you this week. Taking time to notice what contributed to that success can help in the future.
5	Great job staying within lower-risk drinking guidelines. Small decisions can make a big difference over time.
6	This week shows that drinking and staying within your goals can go together. Reflect on what strategies helped you stay on track.
7	You remained below higher-risk drinking levels this week. That reflects thoughtful choices and attention to your goals.
8	Every week that you stay within your limits helps build confidence in your ability to manage your drinking.
9	You demonstrated control over your alcohol use this week. Give yourself credit for the decisions that supported that outcome.
10	Staying within lower-risk drinking levels can support better health, sleep, mood, and energy.
11	You met a goal that many people find challenging—enjoying alcohol while keeping it within boundaries that feel right for you.
12	Looking ahead, try to continue making choices that fit with your goals around drinking.

C — Drank above the risk threshold 12 messages

Shown when drinks are at or above the threshold. *Currently: all 12 display at once today*

WEEK	MESSAGE
1	This week's drinking was in the range considered unhealthy. Taking a moment to consider how that fits with your personal goals may be worthwhile.
2	Drinking above recommended limits can increase the risk of health, relationship, and daily life problems over time. Small changes can make a meaningful difference.
3	Sometimes drinking patterns move us closer to our goals, and sometimes they move us farther away. This week may be an opportunity to reflect on what matters most to you.
4	The choices made this week do not define the future. Every week offers a new chance to move toward the life you want.
5	Drinking above lower-risk levels is common, but it can carry consequences that are easy to overlook in the moment and harder to ignore over time.

WEEK	MESSAGE
6	Many people find that their drinking does not always align with the goals they have for their health, energy, relationships, or future.
7	Lasting change often begins with noticing patterns honestly and without judgment. Awareness is an important first step.
8	Alcohol can offer short-term benefits while also creating costs that may not become apparent until later. Both sides are worth keeping in mind.
9	Reflecting on how alcohol fits into your priorities can help guide future choices in a direction that feels right for you.
10	Progress is not measured by perfection. It is measured by paying attention, learning, and continuing to move toward what matters most.
11	Drinking above lower-risk levels may increase the likelihood of alcohol-related consequences. Recognizing that risk can be an important part of making informed decisions.
12	Your goals, values, and priorities are uniquely your own. Taking time to consider whether your drinking reflects those priorities can be a powerful exercise.

D — Not ready to set a goal 12 messages

Shown when the participant plans to drink but declines a limit. *Currently: never displays today*

WEEK	MESSAGE
1	Change often begins with paying attention rather than making a commitment. Taking time to reflect on your drinking can still be valuable.
2	Not everyone is ready to make a change immediately. Many people spend time weighing what they enjoy about drinking against what concerns them.
3	Choosing not to set a goal today does not mean you have closed the door on change in the future.
4	It can be difficult to think about changing a behavior that serves an important role in your life. Taking time to understand that role can be useful.
5	Many people feel uncertain about making changes to their drinking. Ambivalence is a normal part of the process.
6	You may not be ready to set a limit right now, but continuing to notice how alcohol affects your health, relationships, and daily life can provide valuable insight.
7	Change is most likely to last when it comes from your own reasons and priorities rather than pressure from others.
8	Deciding not to set a goal today is still a decision worth acknowledging. It reflects where you are right now in thinking about your drinking.

WEEK	MESSAGE
9	Sometimes the most important step is simply becoming more aware of how drinking fits into the life you want for yourself.
10	Many people find that their motivation for change develops gradually over time rather than all at once.
11	Whether or not you decide to make changes in the future, paying attention to the connection between your drinking and your personal goals can be informative.
12	Taking time to consider both the benefits and costs of drinking can help clarify what matters most to you

E — Committed to a goal 12 messages

Shown when the participant plans to drink and accepts a limit. *Currently: never displays today*

WEEK	MESSAGE
1	Great decision! Setting a drinking limit is a powerful way to stay in control. Alternating alcoholic drinks with water can make it easier to stick to your plan and feel better the next day.
2	Nice work setting a goal. People are often more successful when they decide in advance how many drinks they'll have rather than making decisions in the moment.
3	You've already taken an important step by choosing a limit. Slowing down and taking time between drinks can help your choices stay aligned with your goal.
4	Excellent choice. Staying in control of your own drink purchases can make it easier to track your drinking and stick with the limit you set.
5	Way to go! Eating before or while drinking can help reduce the effects of alcohol and make it easier to pace yourself throughout the evening.
6	Setting a goal shows commitment to yourself. Keeping a simple count of your drinks on your phone can help you stay aware of your progress.
7	Great plan. A quick check-in with yourself during the evening can help you decide whether your drinking is still matching the goal you set.
8	Nice work taking this step. Choosing beverages with lower alcohol content can help you enjoy social situations while staying within your limit.
9	You've made a thoughtful decision. Spending time with people who respect your goals can make it easier to follow through on them.
10	Setting a limit is a sign that you care about your health and well-being. Mixing in non-alcoholic drinks can help you stay on track and stay hydrated.
11	Great job committing to a goal. Removing easy opportunities to drink more than planned—such as carrying only enough money for your intended drinks—can support your success.
12	Well done. Deciding ahead of time how you'll respond if offered another drink can make it easier to stay confident and stick with the choice you already made.

Closing messages

- **After declining to drink next week:** Great! Thanks for letting us know.
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- 12** **End of the programme:** This completes the text messaging intervention part of the MICA study.
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